Variation in left-branching bound complementizers: बात बताने की (about *batānā* 'to report')

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ABSTRACT: This squib is a preliminary description of a phenomenon in Hindi-Urdu journalistic prose. It is focussed on the complements that are projected by the evidential hedging or framing verb बताना *batānā* 'to report'. Data from three different left-branching constructions is presented in order of increasing degrees of aberrance or deviation from what is found in non-journalistic prose and is presented in non-formalist detail.

Keywords

left-branching, projects, complement, complemetizer, embed, homomorphic, concord, small clauses

Introduction

Like most verbs of speech and communication the verb बता- freely projects a right-branching *ki*-clause:

(1) बताया गया **कि** उन्हें तीन रात-चार दिन का कंप्लीमेंट्री हॉलिडे स्टे के लिए चुना गया है ✓ [1]

batāyā gayā **ki** [unhẽ tīn rāt-čār din-kā kamplīmenṭrī høliḍe sṭe ke.liye čunā gayā hai]
told PASS **that** [them.ACC 3 night-4 day-GEN complimentary holiday stay for chosen PASS PRES.PRF]
'It was reported that [they were selected for a complimentary holiday stay of three nights and four days].'
[navbharattimes.indiatimes.com/business/business-news/couple-invited- … /articleshow/134689806.cms]

This squib is concerned not with *ki*-clauses like the one in (1) whose contents are in no way different from the normal grammar of independent sentences but with morphologically bound left-branching complementizers and the contents of the clauses they embed. The verb बता- projects three different left-branching complement constructions, each of which deserves a description and (some day) an explanation.

Participial complementizers

In this - the simplest type - the complementizer is homomorphic (hamšakal) with the participial affix which comes in three different forms: the habitual *-t@* (2), the progressive *rah@* (3) and the perfect *–(y@ hu)y@* (4):

(2) पास के गन्ने के खेत से मांस सड़ने जैसी बदबू भी आती बताई गई है। ✓

pās.ke ganne ke khet se mãs saṛ-ne jaisī **badbū** bhī **ā-t-ī** **batā-ī** ga-ī hai
nearby cane-GEN field-from meat rot-INF like **stench.FSG** too **come-PRES.PRT-FSG** **said-FSG** PASS.PST-FSG PRES
'A smell like rotting meat has also been reported to be coming from a nearby sugarcane field. '
[jagran.com/uttar-pradesh/farrukhabad-14840105.html]

Compare (2) with (2') where आती *ātī* 'coming' is a participle modifying the noun खुशबू *khušbū* 'fragrance'.

(2') आती खुशबू मस्त है, कुल्हड़ में जब चाय ✓

ā-t-ī **khušbū** mast hai kulhaṛ-mẽ jab čāy
come-PRES.PRT-FSG **fragrance-FSG** wonderful PRES clay.cup-in when tea
'The emerging fragrance is superb when the tea is in a kulhaṛ (a clay disposable cup).'
[sahityapedia.com/post/188515/]

Compare (3) with (3') where हो रही *ho ra*hī 'occurring' modifies the noun बढ़ोत्तरी *baṛhottarī* 'increase'.

(3) बढ़ोत्तरी ... वैश्विक तापमान वृद्धि के प्रभावों के नतीजन हो रही बताई गई है. ✓

baṛhottarī…vaišvik tāpmān vṛddhi-ke prabhāvõ-ke natījan **ho** **rah-ī** **batā-ī** ga-ī hai
increase.FSG global warmth increase-GEN effects-GEN resultant **occur** **PROG-FSG** **said-FSG** PASS.PST-FSG PRES
'an increase … said to be occurring as a result of the effects of global warming.' [news.un.org/…1044222]

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[1] Marking examples with "✓" indicates that their sources have been checked for validity and stability.

(3') मूंगफली तेल के दाम में हो रही बढ़ोत्तरी ✓

mũ̃ŋphali tel-ke dām-mẽ **ho rah-ī baṛhottarī** 'The ongoing rise in the price of peanut oil ...'
groundnut oil-GEN price-in **occur PROG-FSG increase.FSG** [etvbharat.com/…/20230205132511605605047]

Compare (4) with (4') where गई हुई *gaī huī* '(who) had gone' is a participle modifying the noun पत्नी *patnī* 'wife'.

(4) सात दिन पूर्व ही उसकी पत्नी अहमदाबाद गई हुई बताई गई है। ✓

sāt din pūrv.hī uskī patnī ahmadābād **ga-ī hu-ī batā-ī** ga-ī hai.
seven days before his wife.FSG Ahmedabad **gone-FSG been-PRF.FSG said-FSG** PASS.PST-FSG PRES
'His wife reportedly left for Ahmedabad seven days ago.'
[bhaskar.com/news/raj-oth-mat-latest-parbatsar-news-045504-860750-nor.html]

(4') मायके गई हुई पत्नी ने पति को फोन किया "क्यों जी, कब लेने आ रहे हो मुझे?" ✓

māyke **ga-ī hu-ī patnī**-ne pati-ko phon.kiyā kyõ jī, kab le.ne ā.rahe.ho mujhe?
Mom's.home **gone-FSG been-PRF.FSG wife**-ERG husband-DAT phoned well Sir when take-INF coming me.ACC
'A wife who'd gone to her parents' home called her husband, "So when are you coming to pick me up?" '
[quora.com/ ... पति-क्यों-पत्नी-लडाई-करने-का-जो-मजा-आपक]

Participial complementizers preserve the broader aspectual properties of the embedded clause's verb but do not preserve specific TAM (tense, aspect, mood) information nor the person, gender and number agreement features that corresponding *ki*-clauses would keep. According to Rajesh Bhatt (p. c.), the intercalation of any auxiliary having finitizing properties into left-branching participial constructions is not possible. Indeed, the result of doing so in (2), (3) or (4) is the creation of two independent sentences with default to the masculine singular form बताया *batāyā* in the former matrix. (Concord does not normally cross over intersentential gaps)

Although less commonly encountered as matrices, other verbs of communication such as कहना *kahnā* 'to say' and सुनना *sunnā* 'to hear' may host participial complementizers similar to what we see for बताना in (2):

(5) ये रोग यूँही थोड़े ही आया है, ये तुम्हें ले ही जाने के लिए आया है; मधुमेह कभी किसी का ठीक होता सुना है ?

ye rog yũ̃hī thoṛe.hī āyā.hai ye tumhẽ le hī jā-ne-ke.lie āyā.hai madhumeh kabhī kisī.kā **thīk.ho-t-ā** sunā.hai
this disease vain not came it you-ACC take EMP go-INF-for came diabetes ever anyone's **cure-PRES.PRT-MSG** heard
'This disease hasn't come for nothing, it's come to take you; you ever hear of anyone's diabetes being cured?'
[acharyaprashant.org/en/articles/sharir-maranadharmaa-hai-toh-mrityu-se-dar-kaise-1_8f220fd] ✓

Infinitival complementizers

There are two embedding patterns in which the complementizer is homomorphic with the infinitival affix *n@*. In one of them (the more commonly occurring one) the infinitive agrees in gender and number with the subject of the complement. TAM features of the complement are not preserved. They may be inferred from TAM features of the matrix बताना *batānā*, from immediate context, or from general knowledge of the world.

(6) युवक की मौत डेढ़ दिन पहले होनी बताई गई है। ✓

yuvak.kī **maut** ḍeṛh din pahle ho-**n-ī** **batā-ī** ga-ī hai.
youth's **death.FSG** 1.5 days before occur-**INF-FSG said-FSG** PASS-FSG PRES
'The young man's death is said to have occurred a day and a half before.'
[navbharattimes.indiatimes.com/state/uttar-pradesh/ghaziabad/woman-and-husband-… /66610583.cms]

In the second infinitival pattern (a less common and grammatically more perplexing type), the complementizer is homomorphic with an affix which appears as an invariant masculine singular form ending in ***-nā*** of the infinitive as in example (7)'s हो जाना *ho jā-**nā*** 'to occur':

(7) युवक 45 फुट नीचे जा गिरा और उसकी मौत हो जाना बताई जा रही है। ✓

yuvak 45 phuṭ nīče jā girā aur us.kī **maut** **ho jā-nā** **batā-ī** jā rah-ī hai.
youth 45 feet down GO fell and his **death.FSG occur GO-INF say-FSG** PASS PROG-FSG PRES
'The young man fell 45 feet down and is being said to have died.'
[www.patrika.com/damoh-news/stunt-in-train-latest-news-damoh-2079433]

It is to be remarked that in (7) the passive participial form of बताना *batānā*, namely बताई *batāī*, is a feminine

singular form agreeing in gender and number with मौत *maut* 'death', the subject of its clause, while unlike what we observe in example (6) the infinitival complementizer does not agree with the subject. It is also possible to analyze (7) as a partial small clause.

Small Clauses

If the complement is a "small clause" (Shah 1995) in which noun phrases in the complement clause seem to satisfy the argument structure of the matrix then the subject of the complement is marked with the accusative postposition को *ko*, the agreement patterns seen in (2), (3), (4), and (6) are blocked, and the passive or preterite participial of *batānā* assumes the invariant masculine singular default form बताया *batāyā* as seen in (8) and (9):

(8) जिस स्थल-से महिला को गिरना बताया जा रहा है ... ✓ (report of 10 June 2023)
jis sthal-se mahilā-ko gir-**nā** **batā-yā** jā rah-ā hai
which place-from woman.FSG-ACC fall-**INF.DEF.MSG** **say-DEF.MSG** PASS PROG-DEF.MSG PRES
'The spot from which the woman is being said to have fallen …' [patrika.com/raipur-news/…-8300142]

(9) उन्होंने वर्तमान में बेटियों की उपलब्धि को बाबा साहेब के सपनों को सच होता बताया।
unhõ-ne vartmān-mẽ beṭiyõ.kī uplabdhi-ko bābā sāheb.ke sapnõ-ko sač ho-**tā** **batā-y-ā**
he-ERG present-in daughters' achievement-ACC Baba Saheb's dreams-ACC true become-**DEF** **say-PST-DEF**
'He described the current achievements of daughters as the realization of Baba Saheb's dreams.'
[amarujala.com/lucknow/president-said ...] √ (published by Pankaj Shrivastav, updated 28 Aug 2021)

Speakers seem to find these multiplicitous concord patterns puzzling enough to want to omit them altogether and default to the masculine singular. Compare (10)'s concord with feminine singular आग *āg* 'fire' vs (11)'s masculine singular invariant defaults:

(10) शार्ट सर्किट से आग लगनी बताई जा रही है ✓
šorṭ sarkaṭ-se āg lag-**nī** **batā-ī** jā rah-ī hai
short circuit-from fire.FSG start-**INF.FSG** **say-PRT.FSG** PASS PROG-FSG PRES
'The fire is being said to have started from a short circuit.'
[jagran.com/uttar-pradesh/shamli-city-11870214.html] (just three similar examples)

(11) शॉर्ट सर्किट से आग लगना बताया जा रहा है ✓
šorṭ sarkaṭ-se āg lag-**n-ā** **batā-yā** jā rahā hai.
short circuit-from fire.FSG start-**INF-MSG DEF** **say-PRT.DEF.MSG** PASS PROG.MSG.DEF PRES
'The fire is being said to have started from a short circuit.'
[navabharat.com/?p=286187] (about a hundred similar examples)[2]

Abbreviations

In glosses small caps are used for abbreviations and for vector verbs in the senses of their etymological sources.
ACC = accusative DAT = dative DEF = default EMPH = emphatic ERG = ergative GEN = genitive INF = infinitive *-n@* = *-nā/e/ī/ĩ* OBL = oblique PASS = passive PRES = present PROG = progressive PERF = perfect PRT = participial PST = past

References

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[2] In (i) is a rare example of बात *bāt* 'a thing said' (the nominal source of *batānā*) as host of a left-branching complement:
(i) जोगी के भूत होनेवाली बात पूरे गाँव में तेजी से फैल गई ✓
jogī-ke bhūt ho-ne-vāl-ī bāt pūre gə̃v-mẽ tejī.se fail gaī
Yogi-GEN ghost be-**INF.OBL-PRT** **thing** entire village-in speedily spread WENT
'The word that Yogi was a ghost quickly spread through the whole village.'
[hindi.matrubharti.com/book/read/content/19944008/bb-b-by-ravinder-sharma]